

The Genitive Plural — Monikon Genetiivi

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This article describes the usage and the formation of the genitive plural case, aka *monikon genetiivi*.

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1. Use of the Genitive Plural (*minkä, keiden*)

1.1. When indicating possession

The genitive is used to express someone possessing something. When there are multiple possessors, we use the plural genitive. When a group of words all belong together (say: a pronoun, an adjective and a noun), all three of them will be put in the genitive.

Nominative	Finnish	English
nuo miehet	noiden miesten vaimot	the wives of those men
kissat	kissojen lempiruoka	the favorite food of cats
naapurit	naapureiden apu	the neighbors' help
suomalaiset	suomalaisten asenne	Finns' attitude
oppaat	oppaiden koulutus	the guides' education
äidit	äitien mielipiteet	the opinions of mothers

1.2. In front of postpositions

[Postpositions](#) in Finnish are often used to indicate location in relation to another object. Postpositions generally require their complement to be inflected in the genitive case.

Example	English
[Pöytien päällä] on kukkia.	There are flowers [on top of the tables].
[Näiden talojen takana] on lampi.	There's a pond [behind these houses].
Tyttö istuu [vanhempiensä välissä].	The girl sits [between her parents].
Vesi virtaa [siltojen alla].	The water streams [under the bridges].
[Kirjahyllyjen vieressä] on peili.	There's a mirror [next to the book shelves].
Käyn kävelyllä [tyttöjen kanssa].	I'm going on a walk [with the girls].

1.3. When expressing necessity

In Finnish you will need to use the genitive with [verbs expressing necessity](#) (*täytyy*, *pitää*, *kannattaa*).

Finnish	English
[Opiskelijoiden täytyy] käydä kaupassa.	The students have to go to the store.
[Hakijoiden kannattaa] tulla ajoissa.	The applicants should come on time.
[Lasten pitää] siivota huoneensa.	The kids have to clean their room.
[Näiden äitien on pakko] siivota.	These mothers have to clean.
[Poliisien ei pitäisi] olla täällä.	The police officers shouldn't be here.

1.4. Important note

The singular genitive case also functions as the marker for [the total object](#) (e.g. *Syön omenan; Luen kirjan*). The plural genitive is NOT used in the same function. You will use the plural nominative or partitive for plural objects.

Please also check out this article: "[When to use the plural genitive](#)"!

2. The Formation of the Plural Genitive Case

The singular genitive's marker *-n* also appears in the plural genitive. In addition to that *-n*, the plural genitive will also have the plural marker's *-i-*. However, there are many possible options for how the genitive plural can look. In addition, different language sources will present them in a different way. This means that one source might list the plural genitive variants as: *-jen, -ien, -eiden, -eiten* and *-sten*. Another source might list them as *-en, -den, -ten, -tten*.

One thing that will make the genitive plural a little easier to learn is having studied [the plural partitive](#) already. Fairly often, the plural partitive's and the plural genitive's markers will have a similar look. Not included here is [the plural genitive of long words](#).

2.1. Words ending in *-u/-y, -o/-ö*: add *-jen*

Word	PL Genitive	Word	PL Genitive
talo	talo jen	tyttö	tyttö jen
katu	katu jen	hylly	hylly jen
pallo	pallo jen	aamu	aamu jen
pöllö	pöllö jen	helppo	helppo jen

(In the plural partitive, these words would have *-ja*).

2.2. Words ending in *-ä*: replace the *-ä* with *-ien*

Word	PL Genitive	Word	PL Genitive
kynä	kyni en	metsä	metsi en
isä	isi en	kesä	kesi en
leipä	leipi en	kylmä	kylmi en
pöytä	pöyti en	häätä	häti en

(In the plural partitive, these words would have *-ia/-iä*).

2.3. Words ending in -a

The same rules for grouping words ending in -a applies to both the plural partitive and the plural genitive: I call the two groups of words ending in -a by the names “**kissa-words**” and “**koira-words**”. These two words are easy to remember and each belongs to a different group of words ending in -a. If you can remember “kissa – kissojen” and “koira – koirien” and apply that rule to other, similar words, you’re on your way to mastering the plural genitive!

2.3.1. Words of two syllables (*kissa-words*): -ojen

Kissa-words are words of two syllables. Their final letter is -a. In the first syllable, you will have either -e-, -i- or -a-. In other words, the vowels of these words can look like:

- a...a (*kana, maksa, sana, marja*)
- e...a (*herra, tela, teema, leija*)
- i...a (*kissa, tina, hinta, silta*)

When you inflect these words in the plural genitive, you will replace the final -a with -ojen.

Word	PL Genitive	Word	PL Genitive
sana	san ojen	hinta	hint ojen
kala	kal ojen	kissa	kiss ojen
teema	teem ojen	marja	marj ojen
kirja	kirj ojen	liima	liim ojen

(In the plural partitive, these words would end in -oja).

2.3.2. Words of two syllables (*koira-words*): -ien

Koira-words are also words of two syllables. Their final letter is also -a. They differ when it comes to the first syllable: for *koira*-words you will have either -o-, or -u- in the first syllable. In other words, the vowels of these words can look like:

- o...a (*koira, konna, honda, nokka*)
- u...a (*kukka, sukka, suora, juoma*)

For *koira*-words, you will replace the final -a with -ien.

Word	PL Genitive	Word	PL Genitive
koira	koir ien	kukka	kukk ien
tukka	tukk ien	muna	mun ien
loma	lom ien	oja	oj ien

kooma	koom ien	tumma	tumm ien
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(In the plural partitive, these words would end in *-ia*).

2.4. Words ending in *-i*

Words ending in *-i* are once again divided into several groups. For most words, the *-i* will turn into ***-ien***. However, there is often more than one option, of which one can be used in more poetic settings. The following rules only applies to short words. [Long words](#) (e.g. *lääkäri*, *paperi*) have their own rules.

2.4.1. New words ending in *-i*: add ***-en***

Word	PL Genitive	Word	PL Genitive
banaan i	banaan ien	äit i	äit ien
tiim i	tiim ien	pankk i	pankk ien
post i	post ien	maali i	maali ien
tyyl i	tyyl ien	buss i	buss ien

(In the plural partitive, these words would end in *-eja/-ejä*).

2.4.2. Old words ending in *-i*: add ***-en***

I have a more extensive list of words that belong to this type [here](#).

Word	PL Genitive	Word	PL Genitive
jär vi	järv ien	ovi i	ov ien
sien i	sien ien	kiv i	kiv ien
sorm i	sorm ien	nimi i	nim ien
leht i	leht ien	pilv i	pilv ien

(In the plural partitive, these words would end in *-ia/-iä*).

2.4.3. Old words ending in *-si*: add ***-en*** / ***-tten***

- **Everyday language:** old words ending in *-si* will have ***-en*** added to them in the genitive plural.
- **More poetic style:** they can also have ***-tten*** as an ending.

Word	PL Genitive #1	PL Genitive #2
ves i	ves ien	vet tten

susi	susien	sutten
käsi	käsien	kätten
reisi	reisien	reitten

In the partitive **singular**, these words end in *-tta/ttä* (e.g. *käsi* becomes *kättä*, and *susi* becomes *sutta*).
In the partitive **plural**, these words end in *-ia/iä* (e.g. *käsi* becomes *käsiä*, and *susi* becomes *susia*).

I have a more extensive list of words that belong to this type [here](#).

2.4.4. Old *-li/-ni/-ri* words: *-ien* or *-ten*

- **Most often:** can be compared to the partitive SINGULAR (e.g. *pieni* : *pientä* : *pien**ten***; *kieli* : *kieltä* : *kiel**ten***).
- **Also fairly common:** you can add **-en** to the basic form of the word (*pieni* : *pien**ien***; *kieli* : *kiel**ien***).

Word	PL Genitive #1	PL Genitive #2
pieni	pien ten	pien ien
meri	mert en	mer ien
sieni	sient en	sien ien
hiiri	hiirt en	hiir ien
kieli	kielt en	kiel ien

I have a more extensive list of words that belong to this type [here](#).

2.5. Words ending in *-e*: add *-iden* or *-itten*

The genitive plural of words ending in *-e* have two possibilities: ***-iden*** or ***-itten***. Of these, ***-iden*** is the most popular, though both are usually considered equally “correct”. The genitive plural of these words in **strong**.

Word	PL Genitive #1	PL Genitive #2
huone	huone iden	huone itten
perhe	perhe iden	perhe itten
parveke	parvekke iden	parvekke itten
koe	koke iden	koke itten

(In the plural partitive, these words would end in *-ita/-itä*).

2.6. Words ending in *-nen*: replace the *-nen* with *-sten*

For words ending in *-nen*, there is also the possibility of using *-sien* for the plural genitive (*iloisien suomalaisten naisien*), but using *-sten* is much more popular (*iloisten suomalaisten naisten*).

Word	PL Genitive	Word	PL Genitive
nai nen	nai sten	hevo nen	hevo sten
suomalai nen	suomalai sten	etei nen	etei sten
iloi nen	iloi sten	ihmi nen	ihmi sten

2.7. Words ending in two vowels: *-iden/-itten*

These words have two possibilities: *-iden* or *-itten*. Of these, *-iden* is the most popular, though both are usually considered equally "correct".

Word	PL Genitive #1	PL Genitive #2
maa aa	mai iden	mai itten
suu	sui iden	sui itten
jää	jäi iden	jäi itten
harma aa	harmai iden	harmai itten
vapa aa	vapai iden	vapai itten

2.8. Words ending in diphthongs *-ie, -uo, -yö*: *-iden/-itten*

These words have two possibilities: *-iden* or *-itten*. Of these, *-iden* is the most popular, though both are usually considered equally "correct".

Word	PL Genitive #1	PL Genitive #2
tie	tei iden	tei itten
vyö	vöi iden	vöi itten
yö	öi iden	öi itten
työ	töi iden	töi itten

(In the plural partitive, these words would end in *-ita/-itä*).

2.9. Longer words ending in two different vowels *-eo, -uo, -yö*:

This rule applies to words of multiple syllables. For these, you just add *-iden* or *-itten* to the end of the word without making any changes to the word itself.

Word	PL Genitive #1	PL Genitive #2
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televisio	televisioiden	televisioitten
keittiö	keittiöiden	keittiöitten
museo	museoiden	museoitten
video	videoiden	videoitten

2.10. Words ending in a consonant

2.10.1. Words ending in -s

Please look at this overview of words ending in -s: [here](#).

For the plural genitive, you will have two different types of inflection, which you can identify based on their singular genitive form.

Words with *-kse-* in the singular genitive can have a plural genitive that's based on its singular genitive (e.g. *keskuksen* → *keskuksien*), or based on its basic form (e.g. *keskus* → *keskusten*). I've provided the singular form (SG) in the table below for reference when you look at the plural form (PL).

#	Word	SG genitive	PL genitive #1	PL genitive #2
1	keskus	keskuksen	keskuksien	keskusten
1	ostos	ostoksen	ostoksien	ostosten
1	kasvis	kasviksen	kasviksien	kasvisten
1	fiilis	fiiliksen	fiiliksien	fiilisten
1	ananas	ananaksen	ananaksien	ananasten

Words with a long vowel in the singular genitive can have either *-iden* or *-itten* in the plural genitive.

#	Word	SG genitive	PL genitive #1	PL genitive #1
2	kallis	kalliin	kalliiden	kalliitten
2	valmis	valmiin	valmiiden	valmiitten
2	hammas	hampaan	hampaiden	hampaitten
2	saapas	saappaan	saappaiden	saappaitten

2.10.2. Words ending in -ton/-tön

Words ending in *-ton/-tön* will get *-ien* added to their stem, which ends in *-ttoma-* (e.g. *rahattoman*, *rahattomassa*, *rahattomalle*). Note that we use the strong form of the word. It's also possible to have *-ten* as the plural genitive ending for these words (e.g. *työtöntten*), but this is very rare.

Word	PL Genitive	Word	PL Genitive
työtön	työttömien	koditon	kodittomien
rasvaton	rasvattomien	järjetön	järjettömien

(In the plural partitive, these words end in *-ia/-iä*).

2.10.3. Words ending in *-tar/-tär*

Words ending in *-tar/-tär* will get *-ien* added to their stem, which ends in *-ttare-* (e.g. *ystävättären*, *ystävättärellä*, *ystävättäreille*) Note that we use the strong form of the word and remove the final *-e*. It's also possible to have *-ten* as the plural genitive ending for these words (e.g. *ystävätärten*), in which case we use the weak form.

Word	PL Genitive #1	PL Genitive #2
ystävätär	ystävättärien	ystävättärten
kuningatar	kuningattarien	kuningattarten
valtiatar	valtiattarien	valtiattarten
herttuatar	herttuattarien	herttuattarten

2.10.4. Words ending in *-in*

Words ending in *-in* can have two pretty different plural genitive forms: they can end in *-ien* or in *-ten*. This is tricky because the *-ien* ending will be added to the **strong** stem, while the *-ten* ending gets added to the **weak** stem. Both forms are used.

Word	PL Genitive #1	PL Genitive #2
puhelin	puhelimien	puhelinten
puhallin	puhalltimien	puhallinten
kahvinkeitin	kahvinkeittimien	kahvinkeitinten
kiharrin	kihartimien	kiharrinten
avain	avaimien	avainten

2.10.5. Words ending in *-ut/-yt*

Words ending in *-ut* can belong to two groups. The smaller of the two are words such as *olut*, *kevyt* and *ohut*. In the plural genitive, these words will end in *-uiden* and *-uitten* (both endings are allowed).

The much larger group are **NUT-participles**, such as *väsynyt*, *kuollut*, *mennyt* and *juossut*. These words will have *-eiden* or *-eitten* in the plural genitive. As you can see, the ending of both wordtypes ending

in *-ut* is *-iden* or *-itten*, but the vowel right before the plural *-i-* is different.

Word	PL Genitive #1	PL Genitive #2
olut	olu iden	olu itten
kevyt	kevy iden	kevy itten
lyhyt	lyhy iden	lyhy itten
väsinyt	väsine iden	väsine itten
tottunut	tottune iden	tottune itten
kuollut	kuolle iden	kuolle itten

2.11. Advanced: genitive plural's *-in*

There is one more option for the ending of the plural genitive: *-in*. This is only possible with some words: words ending in an *-a* (in the singular) or in an *-e* (in the plural).

Usually this form appears in compound words as the first part (e.g. *vanhempainilta*, *vanhainkoti*, *pyhäinpäivä*). When not part of a compound word, it sounds old-fashioned. It's most common in poetry.

Word	PL Genitive #1	PL Genitive #2
opiskelija	opiskelijai n	opiskelijoi iden
köyhä	köyhäi n	köyhie n
pyhä	pyhäi n	pyhie n
pappi	pappei n	pappie n
vanhempi	vanhempai n	vanhempie n
vanki	vankei n	vankie n
kaikki	kaikkei n	kaikkie n
vanha	vanhai n	vanhoj en

3. Consonant Gradation in the Plural Genitive

The genitive plural will always be **strong**, both for wordtype A and wordtype B. That's different than the partitive singular, where wordtype A words function with the strong grade, and wordtype B with the weak grade.

Wordtype A

Word	PL Genitive	Word	PL Genitive
ty tt ö	ty tt öjen	pan kki	pan kk ien
puk u	puk u jen	pöy tä	pöy ti en
hatt u	hatt u jen	kau ppa	kau pp ojen
silt a	silt o jen	kam pa	kam p ojen

I have a separate article on [wordtype A](#).

Wordtype B			
Word	PL Genitive	Word	PL Genitive
sav u ke	sav u kk eiden	tavoit e	tavoit ti iden
soit in	soit ti mien	op as	opp ai den
ra k as	ra k k a iden	puha llin	puha lti mien
keit in	keit ti mien	ham mas	ham p aiden

I have a separate article on [wordtype B](#).

Small note: the plural genitive of long words ending in -kka/kkä/kko/kkö can be [weak](#).

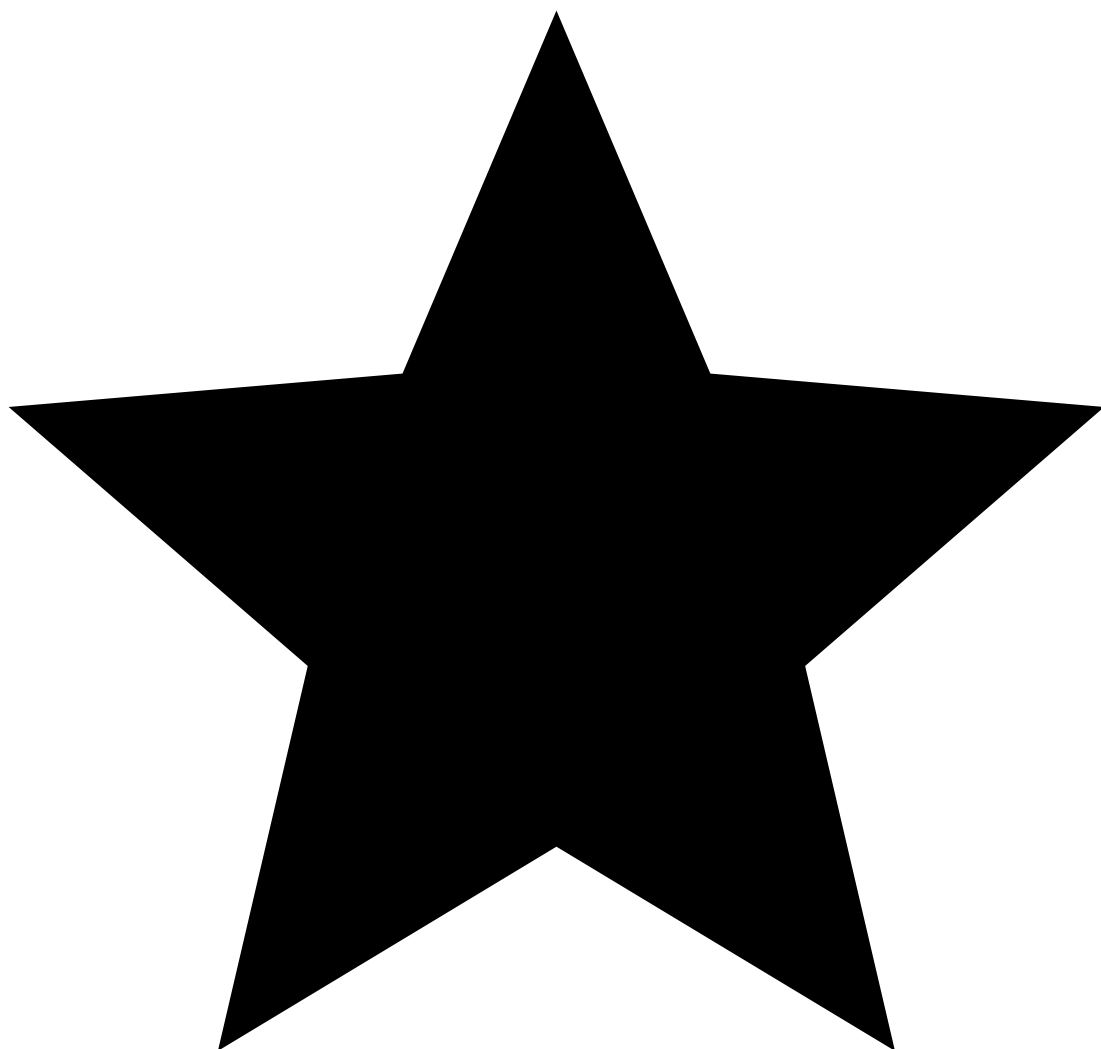
That concludes the article on the plural genitive case!

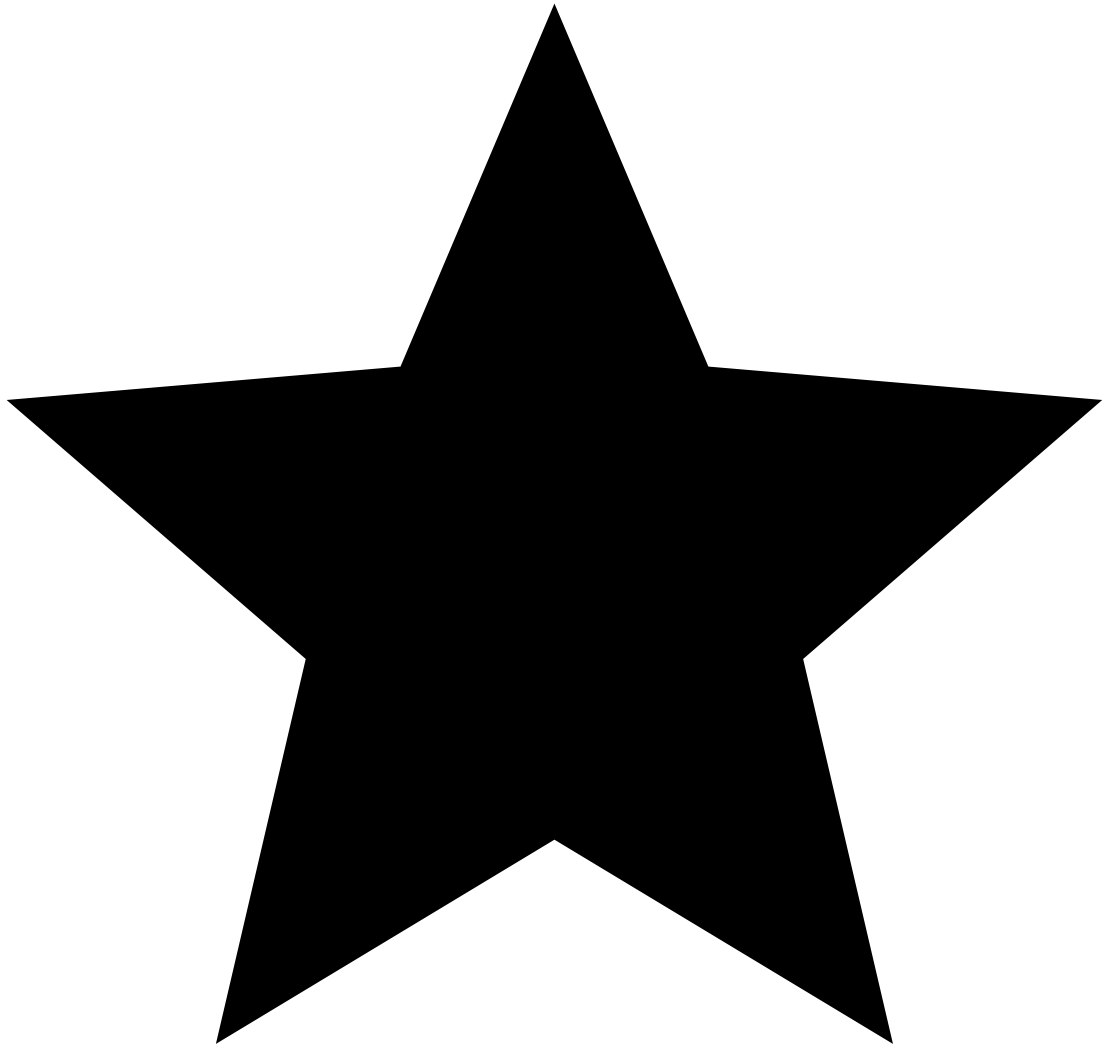
If you want a chance to [compare the genitive plural to the partitive plural](#), you can do so! There is also our page about [the plural genitive of long words](#).

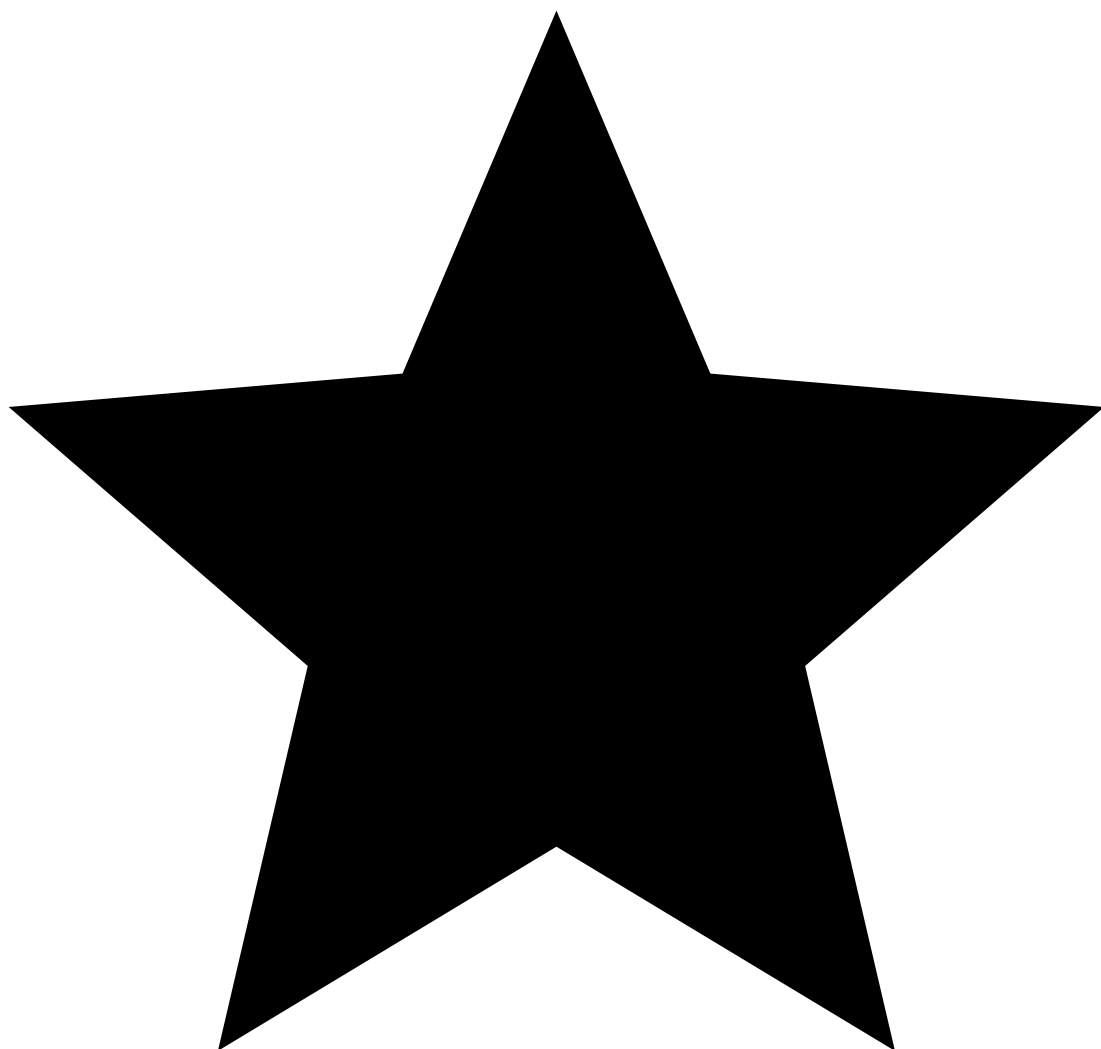
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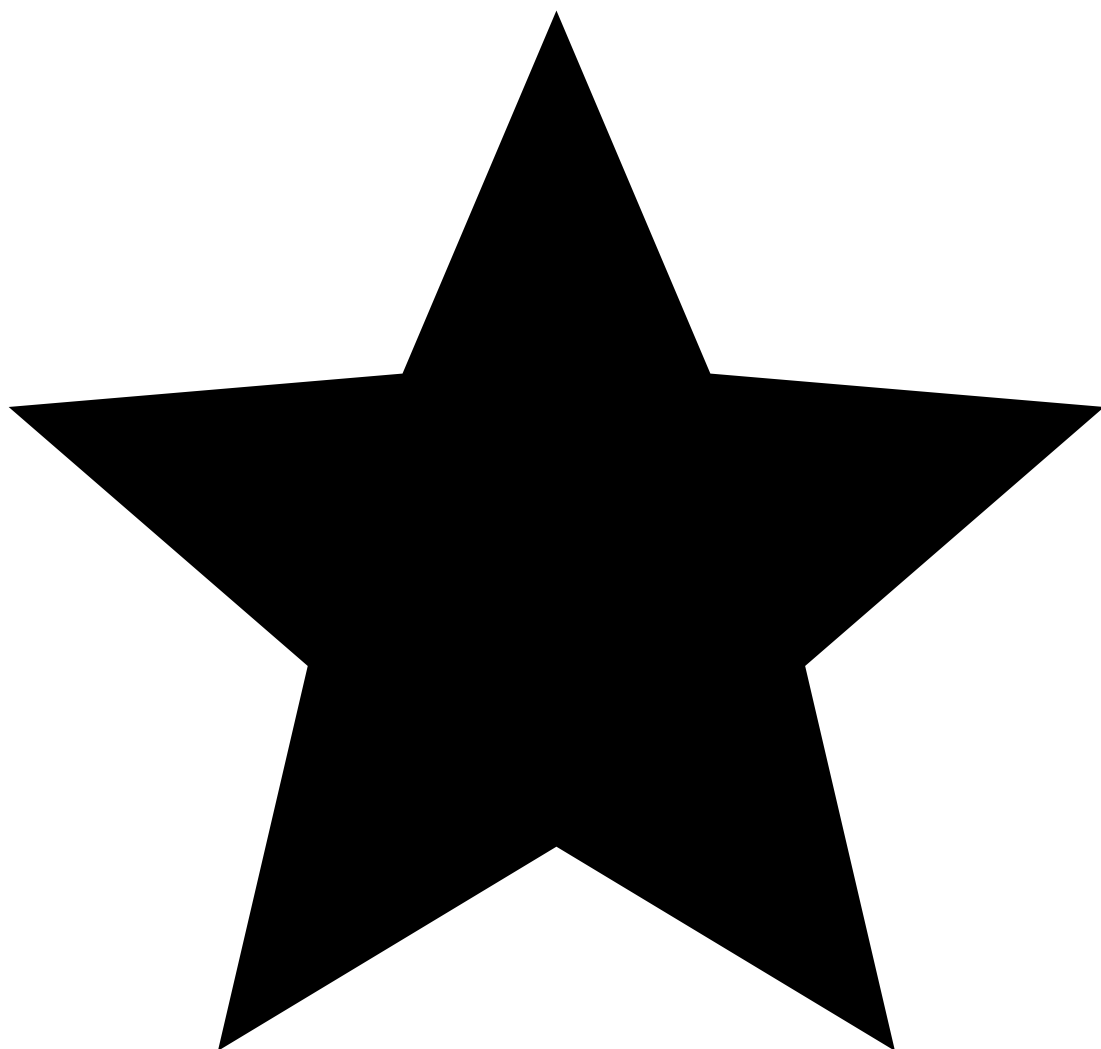
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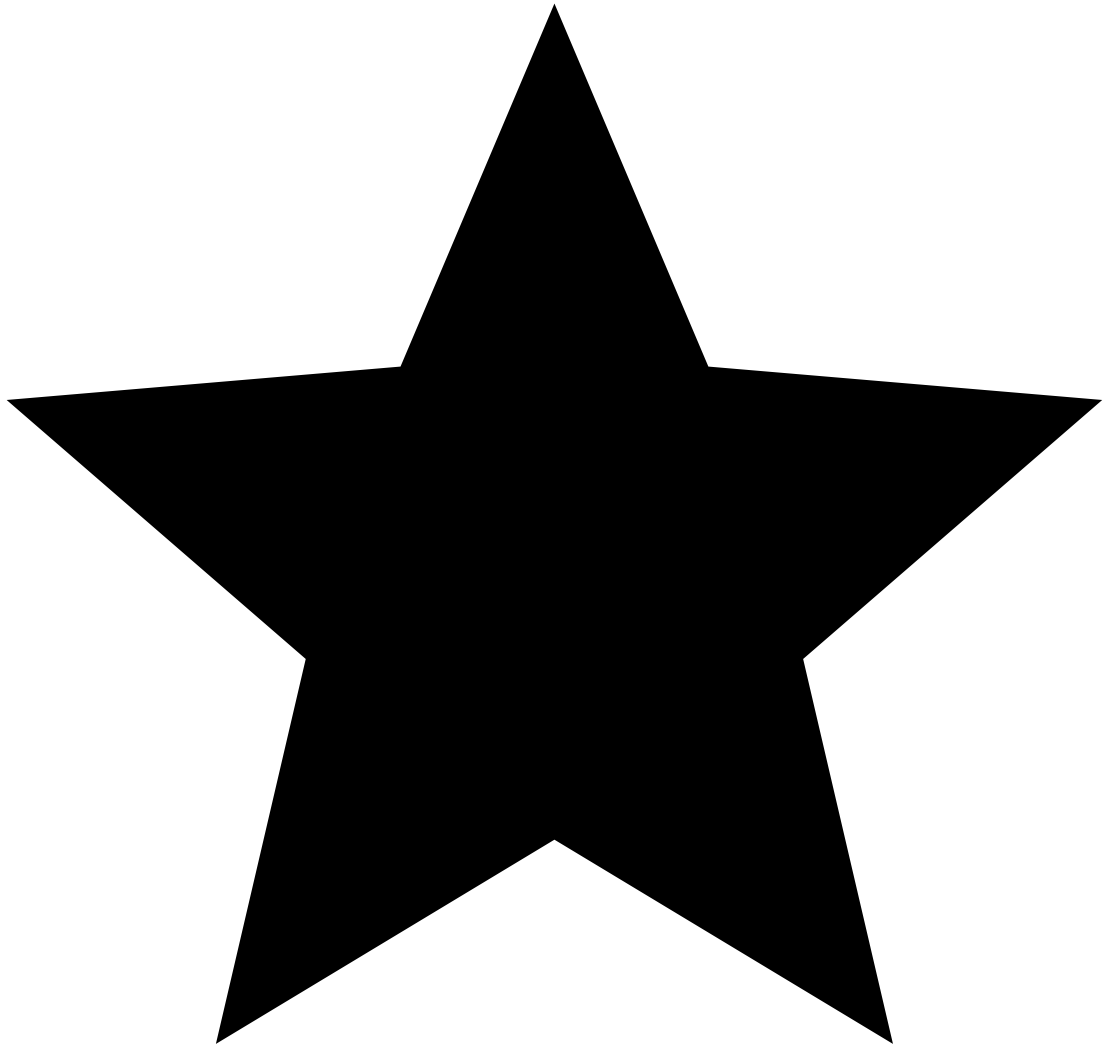
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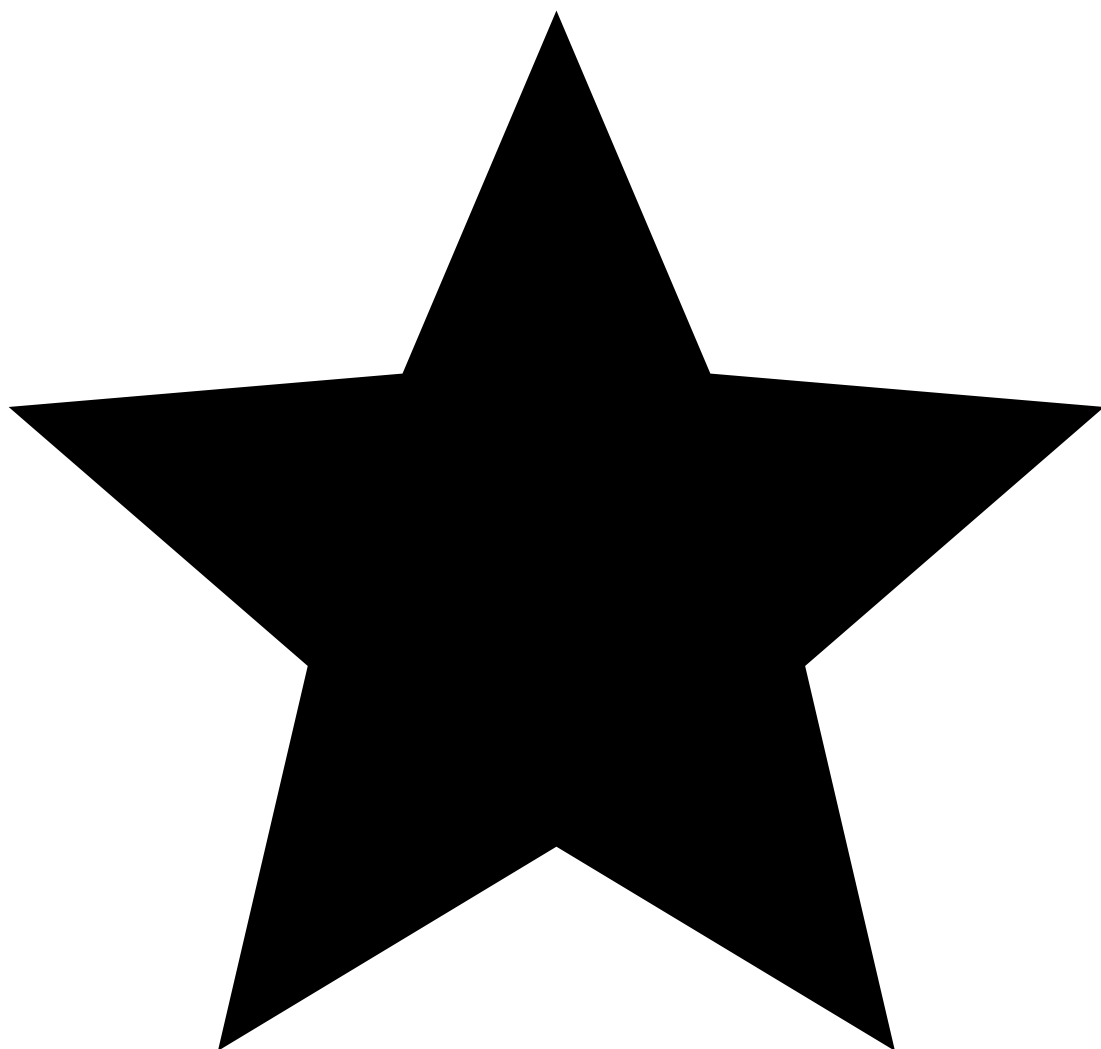


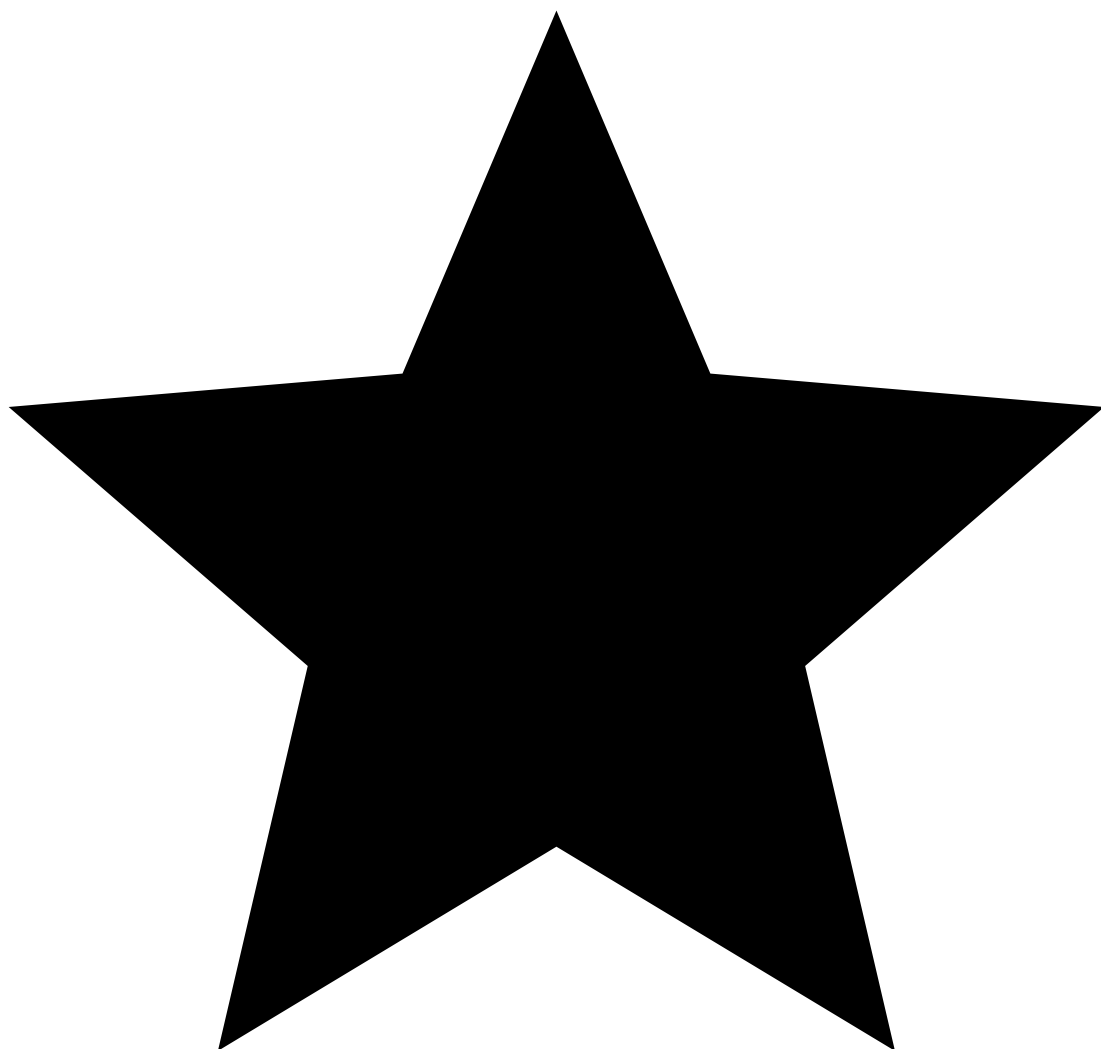


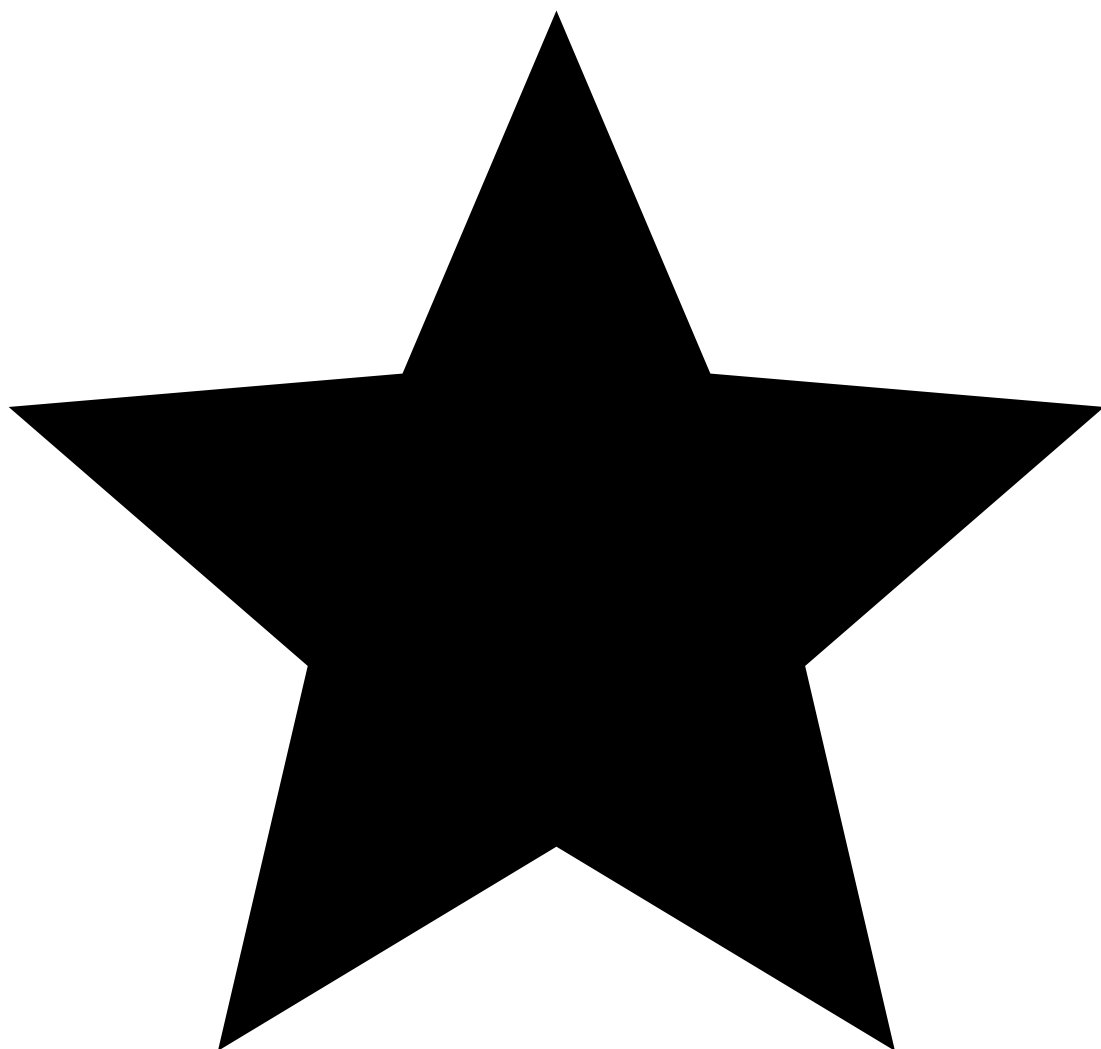


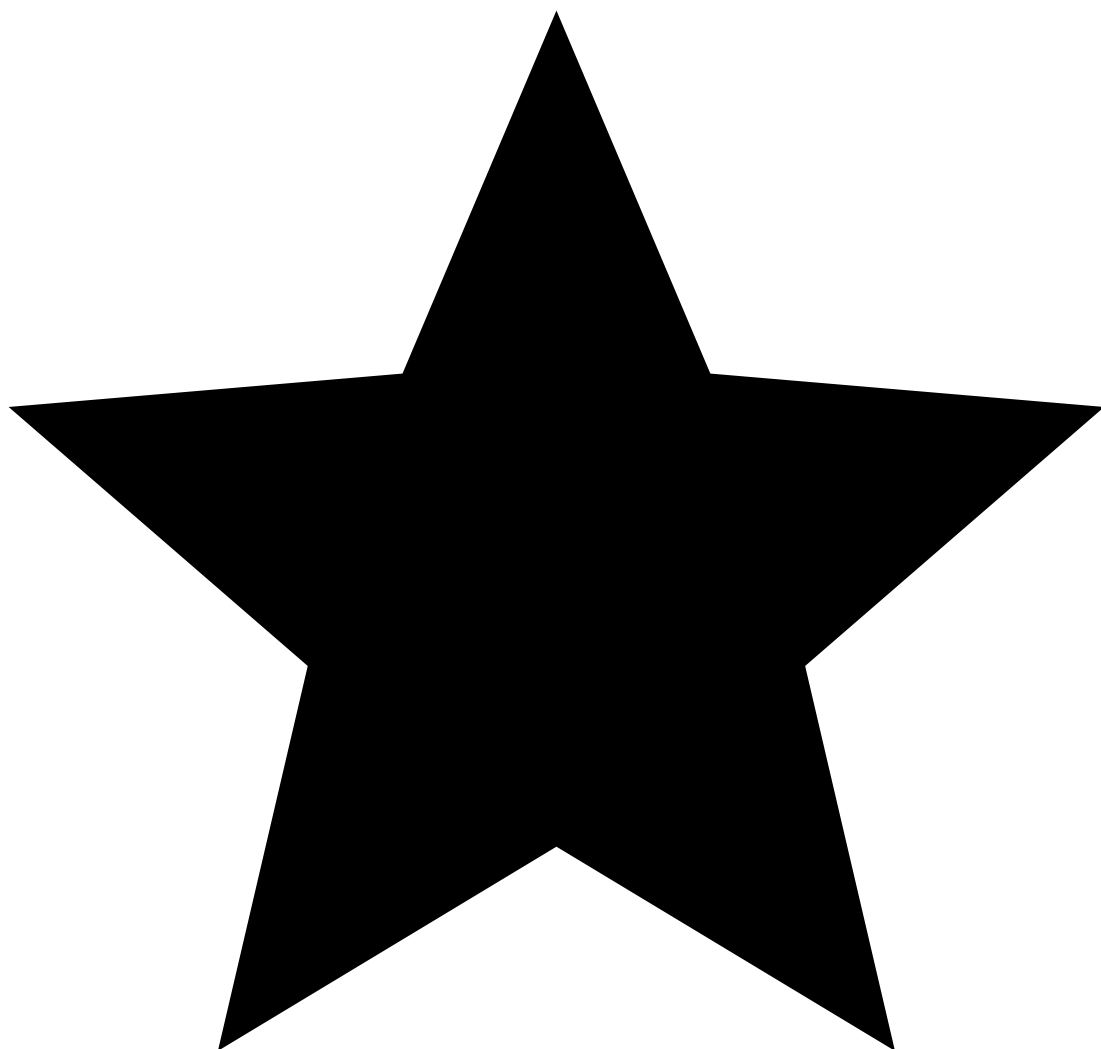


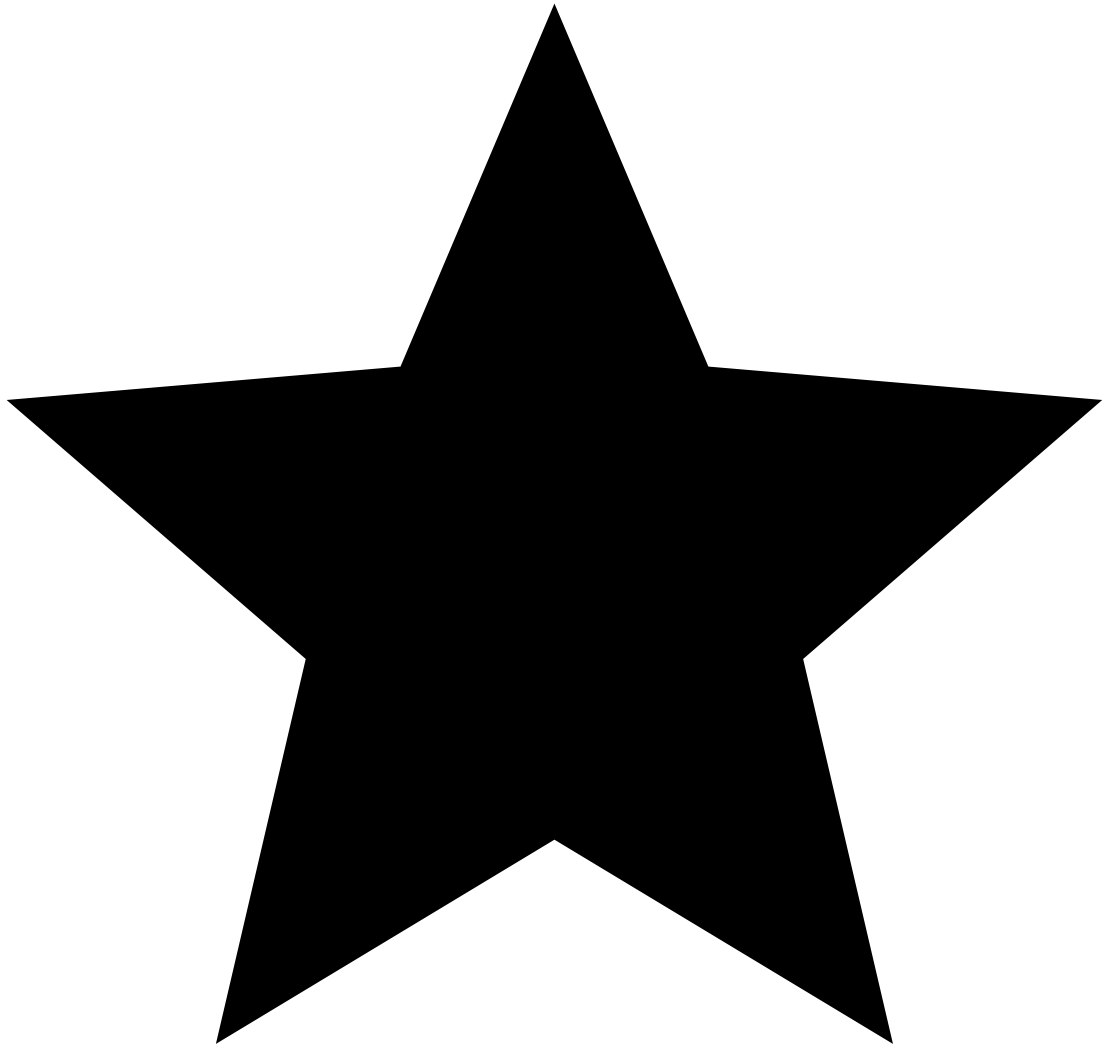












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